

## INTERNATIONAL APPEAL IN THE PRESIDENTIAL INAUGURAL: AN UPDATE ON GENRE AND AN EXPANSION OF ARGUMENT

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The inaugural can be viewed as an introduction to a rhetorical period brought on by new leadership in the office of the presidency. Each presidential inaugural is subject to interpretation based on the era in which it occurred, the passing of time, or the specific rhetorical situation (Bitzer, 1983). Attempting to understand rhetoric based on its unique time period has limitations but can be enlightening. Nonetheless, trends over time and comparisons and contrasts of similar rhetorical events can be lost when only a specific situation is examined. Conversely, a close examination of trends without respect for the specific constraints of a situation may deform our understanding of trends (Ryan, 1993).

In terms of presidential inaugurals, this forced choice between examining trends or speeches in specific situations has limited critics' ability to fully understand the evolutionary changes in types of rhetoric. Specific complaints about the study of presidential inaugurals as a category of rhetoric range from arguments that inaugurals do not constitute their own group (Ryan, 1993), to a critique that the categorization is incomplete (Sigelman, 1996), to a failure to acknowledge that the trends within the category of presidential inaugurals and the unique rhetorical situations can be addressed simultaneously (Lim, 2002).

There are ways of viewing and analyzing trends and specific situations of rhetorical acts which suggest that the limitation of generic criticism is overstated, and that an examination of similar rhetorical acts over time requires a specific critical eye towards allowing those acts to evolve or change. In addition, genre criticism is not dead or lacking in utility, but rather critics' adherence to strict generic interpretations have led to more

debate about the method of criticism than about the rhetorical act itself. In fact, generic criticism may function as a useful short cut for critics that allows for more in-depth analysis of specific rhetorical situations. One component that accounts for both the unique situation and the trends of the inaugurals is that of Presidential arguments regarding American global interests. Since the rhetorical situation is based on the audience and the audience has changed with increased media and global issues in the twentieth and twenty first century, the inaugural has adapted. How the country is constructed and how the office of the presidency is upheld in the inaugural has shifted and so must the critic's eye in reviewing these arguments in the public sphere.

Beasley (2001) introduced a new way of viewing in inaugurals. First, Beasley suggests that there is a link between American ideals and American identity and that Presidential Inaugurals provide a solid textual base for this analysis. Second, she argues that the president "must find ways of breathing life into these abstractions to make them compelling to the American people" because this is the enactment of the office and a reconstitution of the people (p. 174). Finally, Beasley (2001) treats the inaugural addresses as group or category, justifying the study of inaugurals as a genre of speech. It is with these three points that a study of the genre of the inaugural is warranted and, in part, the reason the identity of the people should be examined in terms of the international stage. As Beasley (2001) states, "The speech itself demands it; party divisions must be healed, some level of nonpartisanship must be affirmed, and international audiences and exigencies must be addressed as well" (p. 175).

If Beasley is correct that the ideals of the American people as defined by the Inaugural Address builds the identity of the people, then newly elected presidents should consider the international community in their inaugural addresses. The critic must consider how international issues play a part in the inaugural to build this identity. Most presidential inaugurals have included some element of the international community and those elements have been largely ignored in inaugural speech studies. In order to consider trends in presidential inaugurals (genre), specific

rhetorical situations, the evolutionary changes in time reflected in speeches and other rhetorical elements, this analysis finds that in addition to upholding the office of the presidency, inaugurals are also used to address the international community. The maintenance of the office of the president—particularly in its inception requires an examination of the arguments made to constitute the president as an international entity rather than a solely domestic leader.

### **Literature Review**

A generic analysis is an inductive categorization system used to group seemingly similar texts and analyze their shared elements. Campbell and Jamieson (1990) state that the presidential inaugural address is composed of five main elements: Reuniting the country and reconstituting them as “the people” (p. 17); “Reaffirming traditional values” (p. 19); “Setting forth the principles of the office” (p. 20); “Recognizing limits on Presidential power”(p. 24); and achieving all of these in epideictic address. Speeches in which one or more of these elements are missing, or not addressed completely, suggest one of two things; Either the speech was not a successful and complete inaugural, or specific situational constraints prevented the use of an element or suggested different rhetorical strategies.

There are problems with genre theory. Ryan (1993) argues that genre theory “hinders more than it helps” (p. xvii) because it requires the critic to examine the text with certain assumptions already in place about the elements which are deemed to be important. He also argues that the inaugural address should not be considered epideictic or ceremonial oratory, but rather deliberative. Finally, he argues that twentieth century presidential rhetoric is different from traditional presidential rhetoric and therefore the genre is limited. Joslyn (1986) points out that all presidential inaugurals do not meet the requirements set forth by Campbell and Jamieson thereby suggesting that the genre may be bad. Sigelman (1996) states that, “Over time, presidents have become more and more likely to employ language that is accessible to the masses, have invoked more and more unity symbols, and have done more to establish links with traditional

American values” (p. 90). Sigelman’s suggestion that the genre can change does not suggest that the theory and method are useless. However, in acknowledging the changes, we find that the genre must be more flexible. Inaugural texts that do not utilize certain generic elements of the inaugural, but employ other rhetorical strategies do not cease being presidential inaugurals. Rather, critics must deal with these rogue elements in analysis. This more flexible view of generic criticism may lead to questions about the value of genre theory on the whole (Solomon, 1988).

However, genre theory is helpful to a critic. First, it is an organizing principle that helps the critic sort through the text. Second, once the critic is able to look at the text after all parts have been categorized into the genre, the disregarded text can be examined and utilized for further exploration of the text. Third, by acknowledging that the situational constraints that led to certain generic elements may have changed or shifted over time, critics learn more about the text under examination. Finally, genre theory helps the critic by providing a starting point and a lens, but need not act as a set of blinders. While Ryan’s (1993) and others’ criticisms are valid, they are not unanswerable nor do they lead to a conclusion that genre theory is useless or unproductive. In the Aristotelian view, a talented critic is capable of both recognizing the shared elements of categories of speeches—and the impact of those consistent elements on an argument—while taking into consideration the potential for rhetorical creativity.

In order to understand any rhetorical act, genre critics accept that the situation in which the act occurs is of vital importance. The time period, power relationships, current events, technology, and other elements of the situation impact the choices of the rhetor. Presidential inaugurals are particularly subject to the occasion of the speech as they reconstruct the highest office of elected governance. The inaugural occurs at steady intervals (every four years) and follows similar events (campaigns and elections) and generally takes place in the same physical location. Therefore, inaugurals share elements in purpose and strategy. However, inaugurals also occur in different time periods and therefore will be subject to different rhetorical exigencies. These exigencies call for

responses that may be different from previous inaugurals and, in turn, those responses are indicators of how the office is constructed.

Rowland (2002) suggests that inaugurals follow a certain pattern that is also composed of four elements including that the address be formal, that it commit to values, tell the people where the nation places itself in the context of history and be ceremonial. These four characteristics reflect the spirit of Campbell and Jamieson's generic elements for an inaugural. Rowland's fifth element departs from Campbell and Jamieson by suggesting that the president also address international relationships.

Particularly Rowland (2002) says that the role of the United States in the world should be both powerful and friendly. He contends that an inaugural should "reassure the allies and warn enemies" (p. 223). Intuitively, it would seem that any presidential address would perform this function. The characteristics of reassuring allies and warning enemies warrant a closer look, particularly in terms of more recent presidential inaugurals.

Political speech, and particularly presidential rhetoric, is often divided into sections based on chronology. The start of the twentieth century is a common dividing line. This division of the modern president versus the traditional president seems to suggest different rhetorical constraints and a different set of generic elements. New elements based on the era of the presidency are not necessarily ignored by generic criticism. As previously acknowledged critics may diverge from the genre of inaugurals and examine disregarded rhetoric in a speech for different rhetorical elements. However, when presidents of a certain era use similar rhetorical strategies or have similar elements present and those elements are consistent, then there might be cause for a change in the genre.

The twentieth century presidents are often considered to be set apart from previous presidents by the technological advances in message dissemination. The medium of the inaugural has changed and affects the way in which presidents address the public. Lim (2002) suggests that the presidency has changed and evolved not only in the last century but over time. In his computer

generated content analysis of inaugurals, Lim found five trends evident in presidential rhetoric. He argues that presidential addresses, including inaugurals and the state of the union address, have become “anti-intellectual, abstract, assertive, democratic, and conversational” (p. 346). Of these five, assertiveness is arguably the most distinctive. In the current state of international war, economic crises, and global instability, American construction of its highest office will require a finessing of international assertiveness and Barak Obama’s inaugural on January 20th, 2009 supports this contention. According to Lim, this assertiveness manifests itself as “activist, it adopts a ‘realist’ preoccupation with the language of power and is very confident” (346). This development in presidential rhetoric warrants a close examination of the inaugural in terms of the international audience. Lim’s work confirms a trend apparent in the 21st century consistent with America’s growing symbolic presence in global affairs that is mirrored in the arguments framing the American presidency at each inaugural.

In sum, the literature suggests that inaugurals perform certain functions, but that the list of functions may need some massaging. It can also be surmised that presidential inaugurals have changed over time, that they do shift based on the shrinking global village and American values (Kinnier, Dannenbaum, Lee, Aasen & Kearnes, 2004). Freedman (2002) suggests that a great shift in inaugurals occurred in 1960, “The four decades that separate Kennedy and Bush include the rise and fall of the imperial presidency” (p. 4). He suggests that within that time the balance between the branches and the world order have made presidential address unique from any other time period. However, limiting this study to only the last forty years would not address the issues of the historicity of the presidency and the evolution of inaugurals. Based on this literature, the following textual analysis attempts to answer several questions. Do presidential inaugural addresses “reassure the allies and warn enemies” as suggested by Rowland? Should reassuring allies and warning enemies be considered a new element of the genre? Is this new element evident in all presidential inaugurals or has it evolved over time? Finally, do the

American ideals and identity found in inaugurals reflect a new positioning—the position on the global stage?

### Method

In order to answer these questions, the author examined all presidential addresses for references to international relations. Based on the previous work from Rowland (2002), special focus was placed on the concepts of reassuring allies and warning enemies. Each inaugural was examined by three trained readers who were instructed to find examples of statements that address international relationships with allies or enemies. The readers then discussed whether each inaugural addressed allies and enemies, and how those groups were defined and addressed.

Once the texts were examined, the examples were then organized into sub-groups. These sub-groups were used to define the elements of reassuring allies and warning enemies. Each sub-group was defined by multiple examples from different inaugurals. Since this study aimed to look at evolutionary rather than fixed elements of inaugural addresses.

### Textual Analysis

After studying the inaugural addresses from the birth of U.S. to the present, two trends become apparent. International relations are more important in general and presidents have tended to make use of rhetorical statements that can be categorized as reassuring allies and warning our enemies. The statements designed to reassure the nation's allies revolve around four themes: Promoting democracy abroad, protecting allies in war, advocating world peace, and strengthening relationships with allies.

*Promoting democracy abroad.* The United States has generally followed a policy of supporting democratic reforms abroad, as well as the spread foreign democracy. For that reason, it is not surprising to find statements that clarify this concept in the inaugural address.

In Truman's inaugural address, the President echoes support for democracy abroad with his call for support to the United Nations:

*First, we will continue to give unfaltering support to the United Nations and related agencies, and we will continue to search for ways to strengthen their authority and increase their effectiveness. We believe that the United Nations will be strengthened by the new nations which are being formed in lands now advancing toward self-government under democratic principles.*

Another example is in President Bush's second inaugural address in which he clearly calls for democracy abroad. This statement communicates the expectations and goals of this particular presidency by expressing the foreign policy priorities of the Bush administration or the presidential administrations of the recent past. President Bush states:

*The leaders of governments with long habits of control need to know: To serve your people you must learn to trust them. Start on this journey of progress and justice, and America will walk at your side. And all the allies of the United States can know: we honor your friendship, we rely on your counsel, and we depend on your help. Division among free nations is a primary goal of freedom's enemies the concerted effort of free nations to promote democracy is a prelude to our enemies' defeat.*

An interesting point is that while calling for democratic reforms and promising support for those reforms, the President also attempts to reassure allies that the United States government is receptive to the input from these foreign governments. This is a direct response to criticism that the United States was acting unilaterally in the "war on terror".

Promoting democracy is apparent in the most recent inaugural from Barak Obama. Obama said:

*Our Founding Fathers, faced with perils we can scarcely imagine, drafted a charter to assure the rule of law and the rights of man, a charter expanded by the blood of generations. Those ideals still light the world, and we will not give them up for expedience's sake. And so to all other peoples and governments who are watching today, from the grandest capitals to the small village where my father*

*was born: know that America is a friend of each nation and every man, woman, and child who seeks a future of peace and dignity, and that we are ready to lead once more.*

Obama does not only address the promotion of democracy, but also indicates that America will be an example, an exemplar, and a leader in that change.

*Protecting allies in war.* The United States has often been called upon to provide support to its allies in war. It is an important feature of American foreign and military policy that the nation is able to protect and defend its allies. Statements designed to reassure allies that America will be there when called upon have become more frequent in presidential inaugurals. One of the earliest examples of this type of statement can be found in the Truman inaugural address:

*Third, we will strengthen freedom-loving nations against the dangers of aggression. We are now working out with a number of countries a joint agreement designed to strengthen the security of the North Atlantic area. Such an agreement would take the form of a collective defense arrangement within the terms of the United Nations Charter.*

This statement appears within a larger discussion of America's plans for the recovery from World War II and plans for protecting allies during the Cold War. These statements make it clear that it is a policy of the government to provide protection for the nation's allies.

President Clinton, in his first inaugural address again makes it clear that the United States would act when necessary. Clinton states in his first inaugural address:

*While America rebuilds at home, we will not shrink from the challenges, nor fail to seize the opportunities, of this new world. Together with our friends and allies, we will work to shape change, lest it engulfs us. When our vital interests are challenged, or the will and conscience of the international community is defied we will act-with peaceful diplomacy when ever possible, with force when necessary.*

As with the rhetoric of President Clinton, President George W. Bush promises to protect the nation's allies in both his first and second inaugural address. In his first inaugural he states:

*We will defend our allies and our interests. We will show purpose without arrogance. We will meet aggression and bad faith with resolve and strength. And to all nations, we will speak for the values that gave our nation birth.*

Presidents signal to the international community that the United States is willing to come to the aid of allies when necessary. Obama echoed this same sentiment,

*To the Muslim world, we seek a new way forward, based on mutual interest and mutual respect. To those leaders around the globe who seek to sow conflict, or blame their society's ills on the West - know that your people will judge you on what you can build, not what you destroy. To those who cling to power through corruption and deceit and the silencing of dissent, know that you are on the wrong side of history; but that we will extend a hand if you are willing to unclench your fist. To the people of poor nations, we pledge to work alongside you to make your farms flourish*

Much like his predecessors, Obama tempers the promise of protection with the challenge that certain conditions must be met. This is particularly important in the 20th and 21st centuries as the globe shrinks and America's position must be defined.

*World peace.* Another common category are statements designed to pledge that the United States will be a nation that promotes and pursues peace. The examples of calls for world peace have become more frequent as America has become more active in the international community. During the height of the Cold War president Kennedy makes this call:

*Finally, to those nations who would make themselves our adversary, we offer not a pledge but a request: that both sides begin anew the quest for peace, before the dark powers of destruction unleashed by science engulf all humanity in planned or accidental self-destruction.*

Nixon, in his inaugurals, also references world peace. Specifically, in his first inaugural he says, "Let us take as our goal: where peace is unknown, make it welcome; where peace is fragile, make it strong; where peace is temporary, make it permanent." Carter said, "Tapping this new spirit, there can be no nobler nor more ambitious task for America to undertake on this day of a new beginning than to help shape a just and peaceful world that is truly humane." Obama said,

*We cannot help but believe that the old hatreds shall someday pass; that the lines of tribe shall soon dissolve; that as the world grows smaller, our common humanity shall reveal itself; and that America must play its role in ushering in a new era of peace.*

These references to world peace may be attributed to the increasing American presence in international affairs. As a young nation there was little reason to call for world peace, but as the United States has grown in stature and developed the ability to answer these calls with force when necessary, promoting peace has become a more common feature of inaugural addresses.

*Strengthening relationships.* Strengthening relationships encompasses rhetoric that discusses the general and specific nature of our relationships around the globe. This feature of inaugural rhetoric is intended to assuage the fears that are present with the change of administration—that the change in personalities and ruling philosophy could cause a shift in the nature or quality of the nation's relationships. For an example of how this rhetoric functions one can look to Reagan's first inaugural. The president uses language of friendship and loyalty to describe the foreign policy plans of his administration:

*To those neighbors and allies who share our freedom, we will strengthen our historic ties and assure them of our support and firm commitment. We will match loyalty with loyalty. We will strive for mutually beneficial relations. We will not use our friendship to impose on their sovereignty, for our own sovereignty is not for sale.*

President Reagan speaks of reinforcing and strengthening bonds which may be directed to the nation's North Atlantic allies which were seen as a crucial partner in the Cold War.

President George H.W. Bush takes a slightly different tone when he discusses building and strengthening international relationships:

*To the world, too, we offer new engagement and a renewed vow: We will stay strong to protect the peace. The "offered hand" is a reluctant fist; but once made, strong, and can be used with great effect.*

President Obama used a similar metaphor to talk about foreign relations when he said, "we will extend a hand if you are willing to unclench your fist." In this instance, Obama was referring to those governments with whom our relationships have been strained. In terms of extending relationships with allies, Obama said, "With old friends and former foes, we will work tirelessly to lessen the nuclear threat, and roll back the specter of a warming planet."

As is confirmed by the illustrations presented here, the rhetorical element of reassuring allies is present in multiple presidential inaugurals, although rhetors must decide how they fulfill these requirements based on the specific exigencies of the time. The various rhetorical elements of promoting democracy abroad, protecting allies in war, world peace, and strengthening and maintaining and building relationships with allies categories are evident. This is sufficient evidence to include this element in future analyses of presidential inaugurals.

### **Threatening the Adversaries**

Another aspect of inaugurals is threatening or warning the adversaries. This category is defined by the elements of national security protection, defending human rights, and projecting strength.

*National security protection.* Presidents who employ statements of this type do so to communicate the United States' willingness to protect the security of the nation. The President makes certain that adversaries of the United States understand the

determination to serve the best interest of the United States and its allies. This proclamation clarifies the nation's readiness and firm resolve to take protective actions if the need arises. One example of this type of statement is found within President Truman's inaugural address: "If we can make it sufficiently clear, in advance, that any armed attack affecting our national security would be met with overwhelming force, the armed attack might never occur." President Truman threatens the adversaries by expressing his determination to protect the nation's security. A similar example is present in President George W. Bush's second inaugural address: "My most solemn duty is to protect this nation and its people from further attacks and emerging threats. Some have unwisely chosen to test America's resolve, and have found it firm." Like President Truman, President Bush communicates the United States' willingness to protect national security.

Perhaps the clearest reference to national security is in President Obama's inaugural when he said,

*We will not apologize for our way of life, nor will we waver in its defense, and for those who seek to advance their aims by inducing terror and slaughtering innocents, we say to you now that our spirit is stronger and cannot be broken; you cannot outlast us, and we will defeat you.*

What is interesting about this passage is that it follows a reassurance to our allies. Obama uses antithesis throughout his inaugural to position America as an arbiter, as a decider, and a determiner of world peace.

*Defending human rights.* A subsequent category within the larger category of threatening the adversaries addresses human rights and liberties. An example of this can be found within President Carter's inaugural, "Our commitment to human rights must be absolute, our laws fair, our natural beauty preserved; the powerful must not persecute the weak, and human dignity must be enhanced." Reagan continues this assertion in his second inaugural: "Freedom is one of the deepest and noblest aspirations of the human spirit. People, worldwide, hunger for the right of self-determination, for those inalienable rights that make for human dignity and progress." In George W. Bush's second inaugural, he

also justifies action in defense of human rights, “In the long run, there is no justice without freedom, and there can be no human rights without human liberty.” In President Obama’s inaugural there are multiple references to helping the hungry, the poor, or nations that need assistance from the wealthier countries. He preached responsibility for the basic rights of global citizens.

Several more examples can be found in other inaugurals. Human rights issues worldwide have been a part of the presidential inaugural and can be traced to President Grant’s inaugural in 1873. The international community is an audience for the inaugural as these human rights are valued and their protection is assured. As the international audience has become larger and the role of the U.S. in protecting human rights has expanded, the need for the president to reassure their protection has increased.

*Projecting strength.* Another crucial category under threatening the adversaries is to project strength within the inaugural address. This element is reflective of Lim’s 2002 conclusion that presidential rhetoric has become more assertive. President Nixon is particularly assertive in his inaugural address by stating: “But to all those who would be tempted by weakness, let us leave no doubt that we will be as strong as we need to be for as long as we need to be.” In this statement, Nixon threatens the adversaries and reminds them that passage of time will not weaken American resolve. Following this same trend President Reagan claims in his first inaugural address:

*As for the enemies of freedom, those who are potential adversaries, they will be reminded that peace is the highest aspiration of the American people. We will negotiate for it, sacrifice for it; we will not surrender for it-now or ever. Our forbearance should never be misunderstood. Our reluctance for conflict should not be misjudged as a failure of will. When action is required to preserve our national security, we will act. We will maintain sufficient strength to prevail if need be, knowing that if we do, so we have the best chance of never having to use that strength.*

Like Nixon, Reagan reminds the listeners that time will not weaken the nation's strength. The pursuit of freedom envelops the American ideal of protecting national strength and defending human rights.

Finally, President Obama is clear in his warning to others that they must "unclench their fists" and that Americans will not apologize for lifestyle choices or "way of life." In projecting strength, he does so by explaining that those who oppose America will be defeated and he reminds everyone that this strength comes with a price:

*With hope and virtue, let us brave once more the icy currents, and endure what storms may come. Let it be said by our children's children that when we were tested we refused to let this journey end, that we did not turn back nor did we falter; and with eyes fixed on the horizon and God's grace upon us, we carried forth that great gift of freedom and delivered it safely to future generations.*

As is evidenced by these examples, the element of threatening the adversaries is present in multiple presidential inaugurals—namely by addressing the issues of protecting national security, defending human rights, and projecting strength.

### Discussion

The preponderance of evidence suggests that two themes are present in presidential inaugurals: reassuring allies and warning the enemies. There are several ways that these elements may fit into different inaugurals. First, although most of the examples presented here are from the twentieth century, some examples are present in earlier inaugurals. For example, Madison in 1809 refers to "belligerent nations" and "foreign intrigues and partialities." This might be the oldest example of directly addressing foreign party concerns. The time period of the inaugurals impacts how these themes are interpreted. For example, during the civil war, the president might refer to the south as an ally or an enemy. Prior to the civil war era, there was some fear that foreign countries might try to influence America. This apprehension was well articulated in George Washington's *Farewell address*. During the birth years of

the nation, John Adams makes reference to foreign friends and involvement. Therefore, the new generic element proposed herein has ample support from even traditional presidential inaugurals.

Second, there are multiple ways in which presidents may wish to fulfill this requirement. Outright threats or veiled isolationism can function as one of these two elements. Also, usually the elements are merged together when one statement or sentence might fit into both themes. Rhetors have a choice in how to express threats and reassurance based on the specific situation.

Third, the State of the Union Address differs from the inaugural in several ways. The State of the Union requires specific policy action and the inaugural only requires a reference to international relations. How specific or vague the president may be is determined by the time period in which the inaugural occurs. In the earlier stages of the American democracy, references to foreign interests were more vague. For Obama, foreign relations—good and bad—were center stage and possibly a theme. This theme reflected the melting pot of the United States for Obama and was steeped in the historicity of an African American man becoming president for the first time. The international stage was prominent in his speech due to recent events and the historical importance of his taking office.

This study shows substantial textual support for genre theory—particularly as related to the category of presidential inaugurals. By exhibiting how genre criticism can aid critics in organizing their observations, how the theory might be read with more flexibility, and how the presidential inaugural does not cease being an inaugural with every change, it shows that genre theory is not only alive, but useful. Its organic vitality in fact contributes to its utility in contemporary settings. More importantly, these new elements suggest that international argument is critical to our current understanding of the presidential inaugural. If the inaugural is indeed the maintenance of an institution (Campbell & Jamieson, 1990; Rowland, 2004), then that maintenance must be argued and articulated at the international level. The international stage must be maintained and the American president uses the inaugural to argue for this presence in the international arena.

### Conclusion

Inaugurals clearly indicate that Rowland (2002) was correct when he suggested that presidents should reassure allies and warn enemies, at least based within the inductive genre creation method. An examination of all of the discussion of foreign relationships is part of this speech. While the inaugural is ceremonial address, it is also deliberative in nature and therefore a discussion of relationships is part of the occasion marking an inaugural. The inaugural is not only a domestic speech. Instead, as the global village shrinks, as the world community becomes more connected through technology, and as the inaugural becomes more important to the world, the genre needs to take international affairs into account. Foreign affairs are becoming domestic issues, and domestic issues mesh as foreign affairs.

Times will change and so must speaking situations. The presidential inaugural will always have the goal of reuniting the country and standing firm in a time of leadership change, but it also helps our friends abroad understand the office of the president and ultimately America as a symbolized form. Through language and argument our leaders construct the government for its people and through language and argument our leaders build or destroy a global role—four years at a time.

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